RESUME MASTERY

ATS • ACTION VERBS • COVER LETTERS
GITHUB • CASE STUDIES • 8 SAMPLE RESUMES

A practical, evidence-based resume and application system for Indian freshers, experienced professionals and career switchers.

What this ebook solves

How to build a readable ATS-friendly resume, write achievement bullets, choose action verbs, handle academic marks intelligently, write cover letters, present GitHub projects and case studies, avoid risky design elements, and adapt the same core resume to eight major career tracks.

CONTENTS

01 The Resume Game: What Actually Matters

02 ATS Reality & Formatting Rules

03 Exact Resume Design Specifications

04 Action Verbs & Achievement Bullets

05 Education, Marks & What to Omit

06 Cover Letters That Add Value

07 GitHub Projects & Portfolio Proof

08 Case Studies & Consulting-Style Evidence

09 AI, Watermarks & Risky Resume Artifacts

10 Tailoring to a Job Description

11 Eight Resume Archetypes

12 Final QA Checklist & Research Notes

Research principle

There is no universal ATS “magic format.” ATS products differ. The conservative approach is readable structure, standard headings, truthful job-relevant keywords, no unnecessary graphics, and the employer-requested file type.

01 | THE RESUME GAME

Your resume is not your biography. It is a targeted evidence document.

The objective is to make a recruiter quickly understand what role you are targeting, what evidence you have, and why that evidence is relevant. Harvard, MIT and Berkeley career guidance emphasise concise, targeted resumes and specific accomplishment language.

The relevance test

For every line ask: “Does this help prove that I can do the target job?” If not, cut it, shorten it, or move it to a less prominent section.

Achievement statement

Weak

Responsible for managing social media accounts and posting content.

Stronger

Managed 4 social channels and a 3-post/week content calendar, increasing qualified inbound enquiries 28% over one quarter.

Formula

Action verb + what you changed/delivered + how/with what + measurable or observable result.

02 | ATS REALITY & FORMATTING RULES

Design for parsing first when you apply through an online system.

MIT, Berkeley and Indeed consistently warn that images, tables, text boxes, columns and complex graphics can interfere with parsing. Indeed also notes that modern ATS can often read text-based PDFs, but image-only/scanned PDFs and complex formatting create problems. Follow the employer's requested file type whenever one is specified.

ATS Do's

- Use a simple single-column reading order for ATS submissions.
- Use standard headings: Summary, Experience, Education, Skills, Projects, Certifications.
- Put contact information in the main document body rather than a header/footer.
- Use normal bullets and plain text.
- Mirror relevant job terminology naturally and truthfully.
- Use reverse chronological experience where appropriate.
- Use a text-based PDF or DOCX according to the employer's instructions.

ATS Don'ts

- No headshot/photo for a standard ATS resume unless a specific employer convention requires it.
- No logos, skill bars, pie charts, rating stars or decorative graphics.
- Avoid tables, text boxes and multi-column layouts for ATS submissions.
- Avoid important information in headers or footers.
- Avoid scanned/image-only PDFs.
- Do not hide keywords in white text, tiny text or invisible layers.
- Do not keyword-stuff or copy the job description verbatim.

03 | EXACT RESUME DESIGN SPECIFICATIONS

Use these as a practical default. They are recommendations, not universal ATS requirements.

Page size	A4 for Indian applications unless the employer requests another size.
Margins	0.50–0.65 in (12.7–16.5 mm) for a dense one-page resume.
Font	Arial, Calibri or Times New Roman; MIT recommends common, legible fonts and at least 10 pt.
Name	16–18 pt, bold.
Section headings	10–12 pt, bold.
Body text	10–10.5 pt preferred; 10 pt is a practical lower boundary.
Dates	MMM YYYY, e.g., Jan 2025 – Mar 2026.
Bullets	Solid round bullets; 1–2 lines where possible.
Length	One page for many students/early-career candidates; 1–2 pages can be appropriate for experienced professionals when the second page adds relevant evidence.
File name	FirstName_LastName_TargetRole_Resume.pdf (or .docx when requested).
Colour	Black/dark text on white for ATS-first submissions; restrained colour only if parsing remains simple.

Evidence

MIT recommends a conservative font no smaller than 10 pt and at least half-inch margins. Indeed’s current AI-resume guidance lists Arial, Calibri and Times New Roman and recommends a single-column, text-based layout.

04 | ACTION VERBS & ACHIEVEMENT BULLETS

Start with what you did. Then show how and what changed.

MIT and Berkeley recommend strong action verbs at the beginning of experience bullets; Harvard similarly advises concise, action-oriented language.

Leadership / Management

Led • Directed • Coordinated • Delegated • Supervised • Oversaw • Prioritized • Orchestrated • Chaired • Streamlined • Implemented • Reorganized

Finance / Investment

Analyzed • Audited • Valued • Forecasted • Modeled • Projected • Reconciled • Allocated • Underwrote • Evaluated • Quantified • Assessed

Consulting / Strategy

Diagnosed • Synthesized • Evaluated • Benchmarked • Mapped • Structured • Recommended • Advised • Formulated • Identified • Optimized • Presented

Technology / Data

Built • Developed • Automated • Engineered • Deployed • Integrated • Debugged • Tested • Analyzed • Queried • Designed • Migrated

Operations / Supply Chain

Improved • Reduced • Accelerated • Optimized • Scheduled • Procured • Negotiated • Monitored • Inspected • Standardized • Implemented • Delivered

Marketing

Launched • Positioned • Segmented • Generated • Grew • Optimized • Tested • Analysed • Promoted • Acquired • Converted

Sales

Prospected • Qualified • Negotiated • Closed • Expanded • Retained • Generated • Converted • Pitched • Renewed • Upsold • Developed

Service / Customer Success

Resolved • Supported • Onboarded • Retained • Escalated • Trained • Improved • Monitored • De-escalated • Coached • Advised • Served

Replace weak openings

Responsible for → Managed / Coordinated / Delivered
Worked on → Built / Analysed / Developed
Helped with → Supported / Executed / Contributed to
Did → Implemented / Produced / Resolved

05 | EDUCATION, MARKS & WHAT TO OMIT

Academic information should strengthen your application—not occupy valuable space by default.

If 10th/12th marks are weak

For most professional resumes, you do not need to display low secondary-school marks once you have stronger, more recent evidence. Keep the information available for formal application forms when the employer explicitly asks for it.

If 10th/12th marks are strong

Include them when they add credibility or are relevant. Present them compactly: “Class XII — 94% | CBSE, 2022.”

Prioritise

- Degree + institution + graduation year.
- Relevant coursework only when early-career and useful.
- Academic projects with output.
- Selective scholarships/competitions.
- Internships and work experience.

No false universal rule

There is no universal requirement to hide 10th/12th marks, and no universal requirement to show them. Decide based on seniority, employer requirements and whether the marks strengthen the story.

06 | COVER LETTERS THAT ADD VALUE

A cover letter should explain the fit that a resume cannot explain efficiently.

Do not rewrite the resume in paragraph form. Connect the employer’s need to your most relevant evidence and motivation. Harvard provides cover-letter guidance and sample materials alongside its resume guidance.

Four-paragraph structure

- Opening: role + strongest reason for interest.
- Fit: connect 1–2 requirements to your evidence.
- Proof: one concrete achievement/project and why it matters.
- Close: interest, availability and professional next step.

Template

Dear [Name/Recruiting Team],

I’m applying for the [Role] position because [specific reason connected to the role/company]. My background in [skill/domain] aligns with the role’s focus on [requirement].

In [role/project], I [action] and [result]. This strengthened my ability to [relevant capability], which I would bring to [company/team].

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss how I could contribute to [specific outcome]. Thank you for your consideration.

Sincerely,
[Name]

07 | GITHUB PROJECTS & PORTFOLIO PROOF

A GitHub link is valuable when the repository proves something relevant.

Use projects as evidence, not as a list of technologies. Yale recommends accomplishment statements explaining what you did, how you did it and the outcome.

Project README checklist

- One-line purpose.
- Problem statement.
- Your role.
- Actual tech stack.
- Working setup/run instructions.
- Screenshots/demo where useful.
- Results or observable evidence.
- Limitations and next steps.

Resume project formula

Built [project] using [technology/method] to solve [problem], implementing [key contribution] and achieving [result/metric].

GitHub quality checklist

Professional repository name _____	**Clear README** _____
Working setup _____	**No secrets/API keys** _____
Organised code _____	**Genuine commit history** _____
Working demo/screenshots _____	**Clear dependencies** _____

08 | CASE STUDIES & CONSULTING-STYLE EVIDENCE

Case studies turn “I know X” into “Here is how I used X.”

Use a compact case-study structure for consulting, strategy, product, analytics, finance, marketing and operations roles.

The 7-block case study

- Context
- Problem
- Objective
- Approach and assumptions
- Your actions
- Result
- Reflection / next step

Case title _____	**Business context** _____
Problem statement _____	**Objective / success metric** _____
Data / evidence _____	**Analysis / framework** _____
Recommendation _____	**Result / impact** _____
Limitations _____	**Next step** _____

Example bullet

Analysed a regional FMCG pricing case across 4 customer segments, identified a margin gap in premium SKUs, and recommended a tiered pricing test projected to improve contribution margin by 2–3 percentage points.

09 | AI, WATERMARKS & RISKY RESUME ARTIFACTS

Clean output beats clever-looking output.

If you use an AI design tool, template generator or image editor, export a clean final document. Do not submit visible tool/template watermarks, stock logos, decorative backgrounds or image-only text. Current ATS guidance warns that graphics, images, tables, headers/footers and complex formatting can interfere with parsing.

AI/watermark checklist

- Remove visible AI-tool/template watermark.
- Remove unrelated logos/branding.
- Make all text selectable/searchable.
- Copy PDF text into a plain-text editor and inspect order.
- Open on another device and check contact details.
- Never hide keywords in white/invisible text.
- Never invent achievements, metrics or experience.

Important distinction

A watermark does not automatically mean an ATS will reject a resume. The practical risk is that watermarks, images and layered graphics can interfere with parsing or distract a reviewer. A clean text-based document is the safer default.

10 | TAILORING TO A JOB DESCRIPTION

Build one strong master resume, then tailor the evidence hierarchy.

ATS systems often compare parsed resume information with job-posting language. Use job-description keywords naturally and in context.

Target title _____	**Top 5 repeated skills** _____
Top 3 responsibilities _____	**Required tools** _____
Preferred qualifications _____	**Industry language** _____
My matching evidence _____	**My genuine gaps** _____

Tailoring sequence

- Change the headline/summary accurately.
- Reorder bullets so relevant evidence appears first.
- Add missing truthful keywords naturally.
- Remove low-value bullets that crowd out relevance.
- Keep titles/dates accurate.
- Run the parser test and proofread.

11 | EIGHT RESUME ARCHETYPES

The sample resumes are intentionally simple: single-column, text-first and easy to adapt.

Technology — Software Engineer / Data Analyst
Finance — FP&A; / Financial Analyst
Consulting — Business / Strategy Analyst
Investment / Private Equity — Investment Analyst
Operations — Operations / Supply Chain
Marketing — Marketing / Growth
Sales — B2B Sales
Service — Customer Success / Service

Separate downloads

Each sample resume is also provided individually in the companion bundle so a reader can open and adapt only the relevant version.

12 | FINAL QA CHECKLIST & RESEARCH NOTES

- Target role obvious within seconds.
- No photo/graphics/tables/text boxes in ATS version.
- Font readable and consistent.
- Contact information is selectable text.
- Bullets start with action-oriented verbs.
- Important bullets show evidence/outcomes.
- Keywords match the job where truthful.
- No inflated titles or invented metrics.
- Education is compact and relevant.
- Low-value 10th/12th marks omitted unless useful/required.
- GitHub/portfolio links work.
- PDF is text-selectable and reading order is correct.
- Filename is professional.
- Employer-requested format followed.
- Final proofread completed.

Research base

This guide synthesises current guidance from MIT Career Advising & Professional Development, Harvard FAS Mignone Center for Career Success, UC Berkeley Career Engagement, Yale Office of Career Strategy and Indeed. ATS capabilities vary by employer and vendor; these are conservative defaults.

Final rule

The best resume is not the prettiest one. It is the clearest truthful evidence of fit for the specific role you want.